

Australia Daily Brief

Sunday, September 13, 2026

2,034 words · 8 min read

RE: Vanuatu ferry sinks, 30-plus missing · Fiji says it was not consulted on \$1.5b Vuvale treaty · Panguna camp attacked, Toroama vows reopening · Albanese confronts Hanson · Wells opens digital duty of care to changes

ASX 200

8,741

-2.94%

AUD/USD

0.7173

-0.46%

NZX 50

13,580

-2.82%

NZD/USD

0.5816

-1.14%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Vanuatu's inter-island ferry MV Matui sank between Santo and Ambae with forty-five aboard, leaving one dead and more than thirty missing, and a Luganville MP says the boat search began only about thirty hours later.
- 2 Fiji's Public Works permanent secretary told a parliamentary committee he was never consulted on the \$1.5 billion Vuvale Union treaty with Australia and cannot say what share of the money his ministry will receive.
- 3 Bougainville President Ishmael Toroama condemned an assault on the Lloyds Metals camp at Panguna and vowed the mine's reopening will proceed, while Port Moresby appealed for restraint and dialogue.

• TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Vanuatu ferry sinking leaves more than thirty missing, MP faults search delay

The MV Matui sank in rough seas between Santo and Ambae on Friday morning carrying thirty-four passengers and eleven crew. Vanuatu's government says fifteen people are accounted for alive, one body has been recovered, and more than thirty remain missing. Luganville MP **Matai Seremaiah** said the vessel left Santo at 6am and capsized at about 9.30am, but boat searches did not begin until roughly 4pm on Saturday, *more than thirty hours* later, because authorities believed the ship was adrift and lacked coordinates.

per RNZ Pacific: "We could have saved more": Vanuatu MP criticises 30-hour search delay after ferry sinking" · also Reuters · also ABC News

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Toroama condemns Panguna camp attack, says mine reopening will proceed

Bougainville President **Ishmael Toroama** condemned an attack at the Lloyds Metals camp in Panguna in which personnel were assaulted and equipment destroyed, saying those responsible will face the full force of the law. Papua New Guinea's national government issued an urgent appeal for restraint and peaceful engagement following heightened local tensions around the resource site. Bougainville leader **Peter Tsiamalili** urged people to wait for the Autonomous Bougainville Government's official statement before drawing conclusions.

per Post Courier: "Bougainville President condemns Panguna camp attack, vows mine reopening will proceed"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Fiji ministry says it was not consulted on \$1.5 billion Vuvale Union treaty

Public Works, Meteorological Services and Transport permanent secretary **Paula Baleilevuka** told the Standing Committee on Foreign Affairs and Defence he was not consulted before the Fiji-Australia Vuvale Union treaty was negotiated, though his ministry must implement major parts of the *\$1.5 billion*, ten-year agreement. Consultation was run by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and the Prime Minister's Office. The ministry does not know its share of that package or of a separate \$1.7 billion one; the Water Authority of Fiji has proposed about \$500 million in projects, including the Nadi-Lautoka water supply system.

per Fiji Sun: "PS: I was not consulted on Vuvale Union Treaty"

AU-POLITICS

Albanese confronts Hanson over attack on his late mother

Prime Minister **Anthony Albanese** became emotional defending his late mother, **Maryanne Albanese**, after resurfaced remarks in which One Nation leader **Pauline Hanson** called his references to a public housing upbringing "pathetic" and said it was "not on" for tenants to stay for decades. Hanson made the comments to Karl Stefanovic in February, saying Albanese's mother had lived in the same house for *sixty-five years*. Trade Minister **Don Farrell** demanded an apology; Liberal frontbencher **Andrew Hastie** said Hanson was out of line.

per ABC News: "'Stunned': Emotional PM defends mum against Pauline Hanson remarks" · also SMH

• OVERNIGHT

AU-POLITICS

[Albanese approval slides as debt fears grip voters in Resolve poll](#) · SMH Federal Politics

Voter concern about rising deficits and broken promises has hit **Anthony Albanese** hard in the latest Resolve Political Monitor, the Sydney Morning Herald reported. Labor holds ninety-four of one hundred fifty House seats and faces no federal election before May 2028.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Bill Kelty delivers stinging critique of Albanese and Chalmers economic record](#) · SMH Federal Politics

Bill Kelty, a architect of the reforms that built Australia's modern economy, has attacked the economic record of the Prime Minister and Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** over falling house prices and real wages, the Sydney Morning Herald reported. The intervention comes from inside Labor's own reform tradition rather than from the opposition benches.

AU-DEFENSE

[Veterans press for transparency two years after suicide royal commission](#) · ABC News

Veterans and researchers say momentum has drifted on the *122 recommendations* of the Royal Commission into Defence and Veteran Suicide, two years after its final report. Flinders University professor **Ben Wadham**, a member of the Defence and Veterans' Service Commission advisory group created under recommendation 122, said government claims are hard to verify against public information. The Minister for Veterans' Affairs and Defence Personnel said the government is on track to implement two thirds of the recommendations by the end of this year.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[BRICS adopts 45-page New Delhi Declaration at first Xi visit to India since 2019](#) · ABC News

Leaders of the eleven BRICS members unanimously adopted a *45-page* New Delhi Declaration covering conflicts, trade and economics, with **Xi Jinping** meeting **Narendra Modi** on the summit's sidelines. The grouping now spans Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa plus Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates. **Shruti Pandalai**, inaugural India chair at the Lowy Institute, told the ABC the Iran war had threatened to divide the group.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Houthi seizure of Red Sea port threatens further oil price spike](#) · ABC News

Yemen's Houthi rebels have advanced south along the coast and are choking the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, days after drones shut a Saudi Arabian oil pipeline. Riyadh has shipped much of its crude from Red Sea ports since the war with Iran effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz. Brent stands at *\$104.61*, up 6.83 percent.

• STAT OF THE DAY

\$1.5 billion

Fiji-Australia Vuvali Union treaty, ten years

Fiji's Public Works permanent secretary told parliament he was not consulted on the treaty and does not know his ministry's share of it or of a separate \$1.7 billion package.

Fiji Sun

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · THE AUSTRALIAN NAVAL INSTITUTE

[Australian Naval Institute convenes experts on AUKUS progress](#)

The Australian Naval Institute has published an assessment of progress under AUKUS, titled "Experts look at AUKUS progress". The item carries no further detail in the feed; the institute is the standing professional forum for Royal Australian Navy commentary.

REGIONAL · THE STRAITS TIMES

Australia sets out plan to target cocaine traffickers using the 'Pacific drugs highway'

Australia has a new plan to target cocaine traffickers moving through the Pacific islands, The Straits Times reported, describing the route as a "Pacific drugs highway". No further operational detail was carried in the item.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji's parliament shrinks by one after employment minister's death

Fiji's Parliament will be reduced by one member after the death of Employment Minister **Agni Deo Singh** in Brisbane, announced by Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka**. Fiji's rules bar replacements after three years and six months of a parliamentary term, so National Federation Party next-in-line Parmod Chand, who polled 1,857 votes, will not take the seat. The NFP won five seats in 2022.

FIJI · FBC NEWS

Ro Teimumu rejects claim Rabuka lobbied chiefs to delay the election

The Paramount Chief of the Burebasaga Confederacy, **Ro Teimumu Kepa**, rejected Fiji Labour Party leader **Mahendra Chaudhry's** claim that Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka was lobbying the Great Council of Chiefs to postpone the election. Statements made by people are not always based on fact, she said.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji met service urges public to act on warnings as cyclone season nears

Fiji Meteorological Service director **Misaeli Funaki** urged the public to heed advisories ahead of the tropical cyclone season, with El Nino conditions and very rough seas in play. Recent incidents had cost lives when warnings were ignored, he said, and the message matters most for fishers and people travelling between islands.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

Wartime ordnance still killing and maiming in Solomon Islands eighty years on

A conservative estimate puts the toll from unexploded ordnance in Solomon Islands at about *twenty people killed or injured each year*, during cooking, gardening, land clearing and house building. More than 50,000 explosive items have been destroyed since 2011, which clearance organisation The HALO Trust says is only a fraction of the contamination. The documentary "The War Below: Restoring Hope in the Solomon Islands" premieres in California on September 15.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Tourism worth US\$201 million to Samoa in 2025, visitor survey finds

International tourism had an estimated economic impact of *US\$201 million*, or WST563 million, for Samoa in 2025, according to the International Visitor Survey released by the Pacific Tourism Organisation and the Samoa Tourism Authority. Visitors spent an average of US\$1,136 per trip and stayed nine nights, with about 55 percent of prepaid expenditure estimated to benefit the local economy. New Zealand, Australia and the United States remained the strongest markets.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Local goods drive Samoan inflation as taro and fish prices climb

Samoa's Consumer Price Index for August 2026 showed local goods up *4 percent* on a year earlier against 3.2 percent for imports, the Samoa Bureau of Statistics said. Local prices rose 1.7 percent month on month, led by taro, koko Samoa and Samoan ava, while imported goods fell 1.2 percent on lower fuel and food costs. A July market survey found taro supply down 6 percent and its average price up 26 percent.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Rosso ties PNG growth to fixing land administration

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Lands, Physical Planning and Urbanisation **John Rosso** said Papua New Guinea's capacity to achieve sustainable economic growth depends on getting land administration and physical planning systems right. The remarks land as resource disputes flare in Bougainville.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Pogera district authority buys five vehicles for police and health services

The Pogera-Paiela District Development Authority has purchased *five vehicles* for the law and order and health sectors in the district, the Post-Courier reported. District authorities remain the main channel for service delivery spending in the Highlands.

• NEW ZEALAND

No significant New Zealand developments in the past 24 hours.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Wells opens digital duty of care powers to change after a week of division

Communications Minister **Anika Wells** said she is open to changes to the powers in Labor's digital duty of care bill, after online harm dominated the parliamentary sitting week with the parties still divided on method. Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor** has called the proposal a "blank cheque for political censorship" while agreeing a One Nation video branding **Andrew Hastie** a traitor should come down.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Migrants wary of becoming political fodder as the numbers fight escalates

Labor, the Coalition and One Nation are contesting migration numbers, while an expert argues the debate is fixated on the wrong figure and regional Australia calls for a national settlement strategy. Migrants who contacted the ABC said they do not want to be used as political material.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Victorian Labor pledges 1,500 extra police and a second metropolitan academy

Premier **Ben Carroll** said a re-elected Labor government would recruit *1,500 extra police officers* and build a training facility in the Wyndham area, lifting the force to just over 17,000. Applications are near a five-year high but training is bottlenecked at the state's only permanent academy at Glen Waverley, with regional facilities due in Mildura next year and planned for Gippsland.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

China's biggest bank pushes renminbi settlement for Australian iron ore and coal

Australian miners are traditionally paid in United States dollars for iron ore, coal and bauxite, but China's largest bank says that is changing, the Australian Financial Review reported. The push targets Australia's biggest commodity export lines.

TRADE-ECONOMY · SMH

Report puts scale of Australia's cost of living squeeze on the record

The Sydney Morning Herald reports a new assessment laying out the scale of the national cost of living crisis. The RBA cash rate has stood at 4.35 percent since the unanimous hold of August 11, with trimmed mean inflation still above target.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Auction clearance rate hits 19-week high as buyers hunt bargains

The national auction market is showing signs of improvement, with clearance reaching a *nineteen-week high* as buyers chase discounts, the Australian Financial Review reported. Experts warned any gains would be wiped out by further rate rises.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

JOINT STATEMENT · FBC NEWS

Pacific ministers reaffirm unity ahead of Palau meeting

Ministers reaffirmed Pacific unity ahead of a meeting in Palau, FBC News reported. The Forum chair passed to **Surangel Whipps Jr** at the 55th Leaders Meeting in Koror between August 30 and September 4.

• UPCOMING

SEP
14

Fiji Sugar Corporation's next fortnightly cane payment falls due

Tests FSC's rejection of the National Farmers Union claim that \$5 million in harvesting and fuel subsidies is being withheld from growers.

OCT
26

Advance voting opens in the New Zealand general election

Locks in the campaign endgame for the National, ACT and NZ First coalition and for Winston Peters's foreign policy agenda.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether Christopher Luxon's coalition continues, with defence and Pacific commitments on the ballot.

NOV
2026

Victorian state election

First statewide test for Premier Ben Carroll, and for One Nation's expansion into state contests under Warren Pickering.

MAR
2027

Samoan court decision in the Lise Schmidt case

Ruling follows an admission of misleading police in a matter reaching into the Prime Minister's office and a former prime minister's reputation.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS

FIJI SUN

Fiji opposition demands payroll fix after 134 teachers miss salaries

Shadow Education Minister **Hem Chand** called for a full investigation after *134 teachers*, including thirty heads of school, missed their Pay 18 salaries because permanent appointment documents had not been returned and processed. Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka has directed the Ministry of Finance to help clear the outstanding payments.

FIJI SUN

Fiji offers Northern Division youth grants of up to \$5,000

Minister for Youth and Sports **Jese Saukuru** said grants of up to \$5,000 are available to individuals and youth clubs in the Northern Division for farming, poultry, fisheries and aquaculture ventures, with community training attached. Applications are open for the current financial year.

SAMOA OBSERVER

Samoa passport slips to 67th in 2026 mobility ranking

Samoa's passport ranks 67th globally with a mobility score of 129, fourth among fourteen Oceania countries, down from 61st and a score of 132 in 2025. Of 198 destinations, eighty-two are visa-free and forty-one offer visas on arrival; the United States requires a visa, while the United Kingdom and Canada require electronic travel authorisation.

SAMOA OBSERVER

Samoa spokesperson admits murder accusation against Fiaame was a lie

Lise Schmidt, relative and chief spokesperson of Prime Minister **Laaulialemalietoa Leuatea Schmidt**, admitted in court to misleading police and attempting to pervert the course of justice over a letter to the Head of State accusing former Prime Minister **Fiaame Naomi Mata'afa** of murdering Professor Caroline Sinavaiana Gabbard. A decision is due in March 2027.

TRADE-ECONOMY

FIJI SUN

Fiji Sugar Corporation rejects union claim it is withholding subsidies

FSC said more than \$3.8 million has been spent under government fuel and manual harvesting subsidy programmes, including over \$3 million of a \$5 million fuel grant and about \$805,000 of a \$1.7 million harvesting grant. National Farmers Union general secretary **Mahendra Chaudhry** had said \$5 million intended for growers had not been paid.

AU-POLITICS

SMH

SMH letters judge Hastie's stand against Hanson a mark in his favour

Correspondence published by the Sydney Morning Herald argues **Andrew Hastie's** willingness to confront **Gina Rinehart** and **Pauline Hanson** counts in his favour, while casting him as a future rather than present answer for the Coalition.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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